Introduction to International Politics 1601

Levels of Analysis II: The Individual Level of Foreign Policy-making

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The Individual Level of Analysis

The Individual Level of Analysis

... *or* decision-making at **the individual level**

The Individual Level of Analysis

... *or* decision-making at **the individual level**

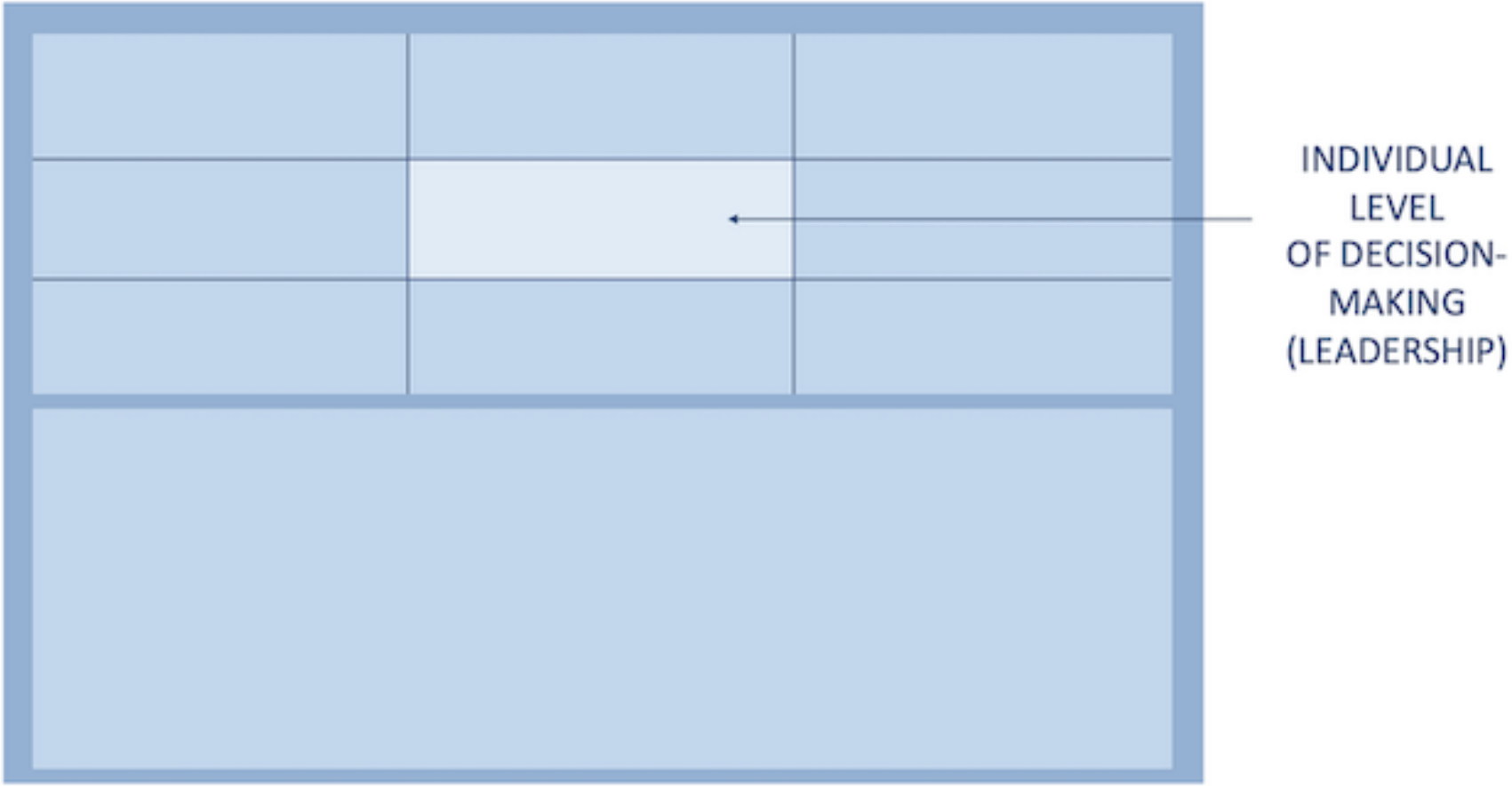
... *and* how those decisions translate to system-level outcomes (where have we seen this before?)

Recall: looking inside "the black box" (previous lecture) -

- we are studying *how states' make choices in foreign policy*
- we consider how these choices manifest as system-level outcomes (i.e., *international politics*)

Looking (today's lecture) at the *individual level* -

- how leaders make choices and how those choices influence politics at the system level
- Arg. - "who leads matters" (Hermann et al 2001)


INDIVIDUAL
LEVEL
OF DECISION-
MAKING
(LEADERSHIP)

How does the individual level of analysis help our understanding of international politics?

New assumptions -

- no longer focus on a rational, unitary state
- individuals act on behalf of the state
- individuals respond to system-level pressures

State and societal level theories demonstrated that other interests matter, as well.

What matters to the individual?

Rationality (or Rational Choice)

Decision-making examples (previous lecture)-

- **rational** - e.g., states, Bureaucratic Politics (BP) Model
- **non-rational** - e.g., Organizational Process (op) Model

Rationality -

- assumes decision-makers (leaders) are utility maximizers
- actors **consider the available information and possible outcomes** of their actions and **choose which action provides the most benefit**
- Examples: The state (from " the black box" perspective), government's (state/societal)

Leaders may be **rational** actors, but they may make **irrational** decisions or be motivated by otherwise **non-rational** factors, as well.

$$\text{Irrationality} \neq Non - rational$$

Irrational behavior -

- acting in contradiction to rational choice expectations
- Example: States opting *not* to balance against an aggressor if no other option is available (Neorealism)

Non-rational choices -

- resulting from individuals being affected by **behavioral factors** that impact their choices, such as learning, judgment, or emotion
- these factors **inform** leaders about particular world events and assist their decision-making in those circumstances

What matters to the individual?

- Beliefs

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- Beliefs
- Personality Traits and Individual Experience

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- Psychological Processes of Decision-Making

What matters to the individual?

- Beliefs
- Personality Traits and Individual Experience
- Psychological Processes of Decision-Making
- Emotion

Individual level factors -

- shape motivations/decision-making
- lead to *misperception*

Added factors:

- Political Environments (in which leaders either rise to power or make their decisions)
- Political Relationships

Individual-Level Factors

Beliefs -

- can develop from personal ideologies, historical events, or other relative understandings of an adversary

Beliefs -

- Leaders can *undervalue* relevant information to inform them of events
- or *overestimate/underestimate* the probability of specific outcomes as a result of their beliefs

Rational Actors?

- leaders may attempt to act in the ways predicted by rational choice, their "calculations are off"
- can be thought of in terms of human error
- Examples: Prospect theory - decisions are made around reference points of gain/loss, risk propensity

Risk propensity -

- leaders may also be more or less averse to *taking risks*
- an individual's willingness to take risks shapes leaders' willingness to engage in episodes of conflict or cooperation

Personality Traits/Experience -

- Leaders' personalities can influence their approach to problems in International Politics.
- Traits including stubbornness, impulsiveness, and being contemplative can influence *how and why* leaders escalate conflict or cooperate with other leaders.
- Example: Differences in U.S. presidents and reflections in U.S. policy

Emotion -

- Can similarly influence leaders' abilities to understand events in world affairs
- Information can *filter through* emotions to shape leaders' perceptions and choices
- Example: **motivated biases** - leaders "see what they *want* to see"

Political Environments -

- We also consider the role of**individuals within their environments**
- Leaders' choices are shaped by how they are compared or contrasted to the political environment under which they take power
- Example: "Only Nixon could go to China"

Political Relationships -

- Leaders' existing relationships with adversaries can also shape their decision-making
- Established relationships shape leaders' image of their adversaries and can also provide additional avenues to resolve conflict

Do Leaders Matter?

Do Leaders Matter?

- compare to state-level or system-level explanations
- we consider regime type (i.e., structure), norms, system level pressures

Example: Terrorism and Support for Right-Wing/"Hawkish" Leaders -

- tensions present between *leaders and political environments*
- leaders may be more inclined to pursue harsher counterterrorism policy when they are perceived to be *too 'dovish'* or too weak to address the terrorist threat

Next lecture: Case Study: Explaining China's Assertiveness in the International System